Salma F. Angkaya-Kuhutan

Salma F. Angkaya-Kuhutan is a Filipino attorney, legal scholar, and Islamic finance specialist of Tausug heritage whose career spans corporate law, public financial management, and advocacy for the rights and welfare of Muslim Filipinos, particularly women in the Bangsamoro region.

She holds a Juris Doctor from the University of the Philippines College of Law and has built a legal practice that is, in many ways, a direct expression of her identity: a Tausug woman who chose to navigate — and change — the legal systems that govern her people.

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BACKGROUND AND ETHNIC IDENTITY

Atty. Angkaya-Kuhutan belongs to the **Tausug** people, one of the oldest and most historically significant Muslim ethnolinguistic communities in the Philippines.

The name itself tells you a lot: *Tausug* literally means "people of the current," a nod to the maritime world the community has navigated for centuries across the Sulu Archipelago.

The Tausugs were the backbone of the historic **Sultanate of Sulu**, one of the most powerful Islamic polities in Southeast Asian history, and their warriors earned a reputation for fierce resistance against Spanish colonization.

Today, the Tausugs are part of the broader **Moro people** of Mindanao, a collective identity that unites Muslim Filipino communities in their shared history, faith, and political aspirations.

Salma F. Angkaya-Kuhutan

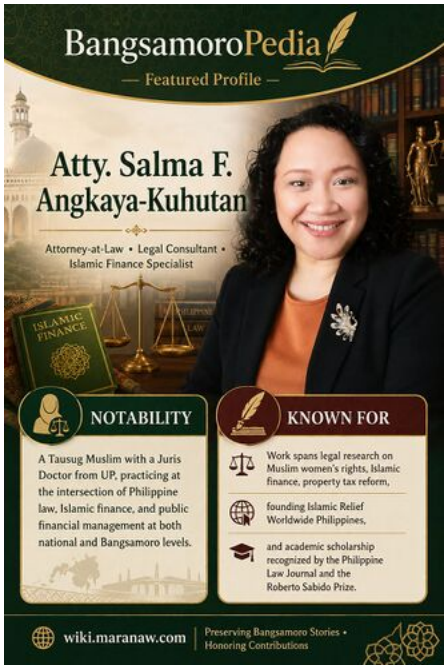


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Full Name

Salma F. Angkaya-Kuhutan

Profession

Attorney-at-Law; Legal Consultant; Islamic Finance Specialist

Ethnicity

Tausug (Moro)

Region of Origin

For Atty. Angkaya-Kuhutan, this heritage isn't just a biographical footnote. It's the lens through which she approaches her legal work, especially her research and advocacy focused on Moro Muslim women, their rights under both civil and Islamic law, and the legal structures that shape their lives.

EDUCATION

She pursued her legal education at the **University of the Philippines College of Law** in Diliman, one of the most rigorous and prestigious law schools in the country, and she didn't just pass through quietly.

During her time there, she earned the **Best Pleading Award** from the UP Office of Legal Aid, was recognized as an awardee of the **Roberto Sabido Prize for Best Legal Paper**, and received the **Bienvenido C. Ambion Prize for Best Paper in Private International Law**.

She also represented UP Law in the **Philip C. Jessup International Moot Court Competition**, one of the most demanding and prestigious legal competitions in the world, earning a citation for her participation.

Before law school, she completed her undergraduate degree in **Business Administration** at the UP College of Business Administration, graduating **cum laude**.

She also holds a degree in **Real Estate Management** from Lyceum of Alabang, rounding out a professional formation that is unusual even by the standards of Manila's top legal practitioners: business-trained, academically decorated, and grounded in the practical worlds of property, commerce, and governance.

LEGAL CAREER

Early Career in Top-Tier Law Firms

After passing the bar, Atty. Angkaya-Kuhutan began her legal career at some of the most respected law firms in the country.

She worked with **Castillo Laman Tan Pantaleon & San Jose Law Offices**, **Puyat Jacinto & Santos Law Offices**, and **Poblador Bautista & Reyes Law Offices**, handling the kind of complex, high-stakes work that defines elite commercial practice in the Philippines: mergers and acquisitions, investment structuring, public-private partnerships, privatization, project finance, banking, insurance, and capital markets transactions.

Sulu Archipelago, Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)

Law Degree

Juris Doctor, University of the Philippines College of Law

Undergraduate Degrees

BS Business Administration, *Cum Laude*, UP College of Business Administration
BS Real Estate Management, Lyceum of Alabang

Bar Membership

Integrated Bar of the Philippines

Islamic Finance Credential

Fellow and Certified Shari'ah Advisor and Auditor (CSAA), AAOIFI
Honorary Fellow and Certified Islamic Arbitrator and Expert, IICRA

Areas of Practice

Corporate and Commercial Law; Islamic Finance; Public Finance Management; PPP; Civil and Family Law; Tax Law; Real Estate; Labor Law; Intellectual Property

Notable Affiliations

She also handled corporate housekeeping and regulatory compliance, and reviewed contracts and commercial agreements across a remarkably wide range of sectors, from energy and mining to healthcare, tourism, and fintech.

General Practice and Consultancy

Today, she manages her own general law practice while serving as **legal counsel, corporate secretary, and consultant** for a diverse portfolio of clients: government agencies, multilateral development banks, non-government organizations, and private entities in real estate, construction, manufacturing, and financial technology.

Her practice covers corporate and commercial law, civil and family law, labor disputes, and property matters, and she has represented SMEs, families, and individuals in a wide range of legal situations.

She has also taught **business courses** at the UP School of Economics and the UP College of Business Administration, bringing her practitioner's perspective into the classroom while completing her law degree.

PUBLIC FINANCE AND GOVERNMENT WORK

One of the most distinctive threads in Atty. Angkaya-Kuhutan's career is her deep engagement with **public financial management** and government reform, work that has taken her from Manila's central government offices to development bank corridors and, ultimately, to the Bangsamoro itself.

She was part of the legal team advising the **PPP Center** and project sponsors on feasibility studies, project structuring, and legal documentation for public-private partnerships.

World Bank; Asian Development Bank; PPP Center (Philippines); Department of Finance (Philippines); BARMM Ministry of Finance and Budget and Management; Islamic Relief Worldwide (Philippines Branch); HealthJustice Philippines; Oxfam Pilipinas; Philippine Chamber of Commerce and Industry (Parañaque City)

Notability

One of a very small number of Tausug Muslim women to hold a Juris Doctor from the University of the Philippines and to practice at the intersection of Philippine law, Islamic finance, and public financial management at both the national and Bangsamoro regional level.

Known For

Legal research on Moro Muslim women's rights; Islamic finance consultancy for BARMM; property tax reform advocacy; establishment of the Philippine branch of Islamic Relief Worldwide; academic scholarship recognized by the Philippine Law Journal and the Roberto Sabido Prize.

At the **Department of Finance**, she worked on internal revenue, customs, and local treasury operations.

She held key consultancy positions with the **World Bank** and the **Asian Development Bank**, contributing to significant tax policy reforms and public financial management frameworks.

Her work with the **Bureau of Local Government Finance** supported property tax reforms and local revenue generation, including providing assistance in the passage of the **Real Property Valuation and Assessment Reform Act**, a landmark piece of legislation that modernized property valuation across the country.

BANGSAMORO AND ISLAMIC FINANCE WORK

Perhaps the most personally resonant dimension of her career is her work as an **Islamic finance consultant** to the **Ministry of Finance and Budget and Management of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)**.

This role puts her at the intersection of two worlds she knows deeply: the technical machinery of Philippine public finance law and the distinct legal and ethical framework of Islamic finance.

Islamic finance operates on principles derived from Shari'ah, prohibiting interest (*riba*) and emphasizing equity, risk-sharing, and ethical investment. Integrating these principles into the governance and budget structures of the Bangsamoro is not a simple legal exercise. It requires someone who can read both systems fluently and help bridge them in a way that is legally sound and culturally grounded.

She brings formal credentials to this work. She is a **Fellow and Certified Shari'ah Advisor and Auditor (CSAA)** of the Accounting and Auditing Organization for Islamic Financial Institutions (**AAOIFI**), the leading international standard-setting body for Islamic finance. She is also an **Honorary Fellow and Certified Islamic Arbitrator and Expert** of the International Islamic Centre for Reconciliation and Arbitration (**IICRA**).

ACADEMIC SCHOLARSHIP

Atty. Angkaya-Kuhutan has also contributed to legal scholarship, with work published in the **Philippine Law Journal**, one of the oldest and most prestigious law reviews in the country, and recognized by institutions including the Randwick Research International Social Science Journal.

Her academic writing engages directly with the legal position of Moro Muslim women, examining the protections, gaps, and possibilities within both the Philippine legal framework and Islamic law.

This scholarship reflects a larger commitment: to make visible the legal realities of a community that has often been underrepresented in both legal academia and formal governance.

HUMANITARIAN AND NGO WORK

Beyond her legal and consultancy practice, she has contributed meaningfully to the humanitarian sector.

She was instrumental in establishing the **Philippine branch of Islamic Relief Worldwide** in the aftermath of **Typhoon Yolanda** (Haiyan) in 2013, one of the strongest typhoons ever recorded, which devastated communities across the Visayas and parts of Mindanao.

Islamic Relief is one of the world's largest Muslim humanitarian organizations, and bringing its Philippine operations to life in the immediate aftermath of a catastrophic disaster required not just legal skill but genuine dedication to community service.

She has also provided consultancy services to **HealthJustice Philippines** and **Oxfam Pilipinas**, organizations working at the intersection of public health, social justice, and development in the Philippines.

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

- Member, **Integrated Bar of the Philippines**
- Fellow and Certified Shari'ah Advisor and Auditor (CSAA), **Accounting and Auditing Organization for Islamic Financial Institutions (AAOIFI)**
- Honorary Fellow and Certified Islamic Arbitrator and Expert, **International Islamic Centre for Reconciliation and Arbitration (IICRA)**
- Member, **National Association of Data Privacy Officers of the Philippines (NADPOP)**
- Board Member, **Philippine Chamber of Commerce and Industry (PCCI)**, Parañaque City Chapter

SEE ALSO

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
- Tausug people
- Sultanate of Sulu
- Moro people
- Islamic finance in the Philippines
- University of the Philippines College of Law
- Real Property Valuation and Assessment Reform Act

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